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1920, ‘Lal Bal Pal’

Long before Gandhi had made a political impact on the Indian liberation struggle, it was Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal and Lala Lajpat Rai who, having laid the bedrock for muscular and uncompromising nationalism, propelled themselves into the national consciousness as the triad of ‘Bal Pal Lal’ within the Congress Party, thus establishing the roots of its radicalization. Today the names of ‘Bal Pal Lal’ are all but forgotten, even in the Indian subcontinent. Yet in their time, these three were a force to contend with. It was they who turned the Congress Party from a pro-government to an anti-government force. Although Gandhi had assumed leadership of the Congress Party in 1920, from where he would call for non-cooperation with the British even after the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre in Amritsar in 1919, Lajpat Rai in Lahore would have none of it. He was much more popular than Gandhi in Punjab. Thereafter, although he grudgingly went along with Mahatma Gandhi’s non-cooperation programme for the two years that it lasted, he was convinced that as an ideology it would fail. In February 1922, after policemen shot down twenty-five protesters in Chauri Chaura in Uttar Pradesh, he demanded that Gandhi renounce this strategy altogether. Not unnaturally, given the stance that these three militant nationalists adopted, they were regarded within the Congress Party as extremists. The epithet was not inaccurate for, unlike the rest of the Congress Party who believed in sharing power with the British, these three stood for complete autonomy for India within the Empire. Such was their transformative impact that prior to their arrival on the scene the Indian National Congress was widely known to be a pro-Empire party with an abiding belief in benign colonialism.